hundred and twenty five days in a hundred and sixteen districts of the six large states in which migrants were returning.

Taking into account the prime minister's directions and vision, several states conducted the skill-mapping exercise, even before the migrants were discharged from the mandatory 14-day quarantine. To their pleasant surprise, many of them concluded that most returned workers were highly skilled in their respective domains and knowledgeable of verticals of the production chain. In response, states began to form district-level committees of officials who would assist in providing space, procuring machinery, raw material sourcing, organizing funds and conducting training workshops so as to help small-scale, self-sustaining industries start up. Several success stories have emerged out of this model and several new industrial hubs have now developed.[6]

To note, government expenditure on the main subsidy items of food, oil and fertilizers rose steeply by 90 per cent amounting to ₹291.9 billion in October 2020. These numbers are suggestive of the government's intent to spend on projects which had the potential to lead to more job creation, thus compounding the yields. In other words, adopting the modified barbell strategy, as soon as the economy began to show signs of recovery August 2020 onwards, taking into account on-ground feedback, the government increased its expenditure in sectors which yielded multiplier effects on growth. As a result of these targeted efforts, GST collections crossed ₹1 trillion for the first time in eight months resting on strong growth markers such as reduction in unemployment rates to pre-COVID levels, a strong NIFTY index higher than that of the previous year, industrial activity picking up and substantial improvements in port traffic, railway freight traffic and electricity generation.[7] After two consecutive quarters of economic contraction, the country's GDP entered into positive territory in the last quarter of the fiscal year and foreign reserves remained at an all-time high, suggesting that India was heading towards a very encouraging V-shaped economic recovery.[8]

◆

**28 OCTOBER 2020**

INDIA | 6,02,473 ACTIVE CASES | 1,21,341 DEATHS